SUMMARY HANDOUT — CHAPTER 1

Scoping your course

Summary handout — Demo course “Designing an online course”

Contents

- 1. The audience, first
- 2. Objectives you can verify
- 3. The through-line

Three decisions come **before** writing a single line: for whom, to do what, and around what. Each constrains the next. Skipping them does not save time — it moves the time to the rewrite.

1. The audience, first

Until you know who is learning, you can neither set a reachable objective nor judge whether a through-line will land. A useful audience is described by its **actual prerequisites**, its **available time** and its **practical constraints**. The third is the forgotten one, and often the decisive one: a learner on a commute will not watch a twenty-minute video.

> **“Master's students” describes nobody**
> A degree label supports no decision. Write the profile down at the top of the syllabus: it will settle every difficult decision later.

2. Objectives you can verify

An objective states what the learner will be able to **do**, not what they will have “seen” or “understood”. The difference decides whether you can assess at all. The test: if you cannot picture the exercise that would prove it reached, it is badly written.

3. The through-line

A case, a project or a scenario running across the whole course. It answers in advance the question asked at every chapter: “what will this be used for?”. It is also the arbiter on the day you must cut: what does not serve it is what you can do without.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Three decisions, in order: for whom, to do what, around what.
- An audience is described by its constraints, not by its degree.
- An objective is verifiable or it is nothing.
- The through-line answers “what is this for” before it is asked.

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